



The Spanish Armada

The sea was described as “groaning under the weight” of the Spanish fleet sent to attack England in 1588. The decisive defeat of the armada was Elizabeth’s finest hour.

had every reason to distrust a sister who could be put forward as a Protestant candidate for the throne. Elizabeth survived by steering clear of plots against Mary and maintaining a facade of loyalty. The worst she suffered was a brief imprisonment in the Tower of London, in 1554.

The Golden Age

The early deaths of her siblings brought Elizabeth to the throne at the age of 25. From the start of her reign, she chose her advisers well, especially her chief secretary of state, William Cecil. The goal she set them was the survival of her person and her state—a goal dictating

caution, suspicion, and ruthlessness when required. Elizabeth refused to endorse Protestant extremism, insisting on royal control over the Church but trying to avoid complex issues of doctrine. Plots and rebellions by English and Irish Catholics plagued her reign, and she had her cousin, Mary Queen of Scots, imprisoned and eventually executed as a dangerous Catholic claimant to the throne. Elizabeth similarly attempted to avoid involvement in the religious wars racking Europe, but was reluctantly drawn into backing the Protestant Dutch against Catholic Spain.

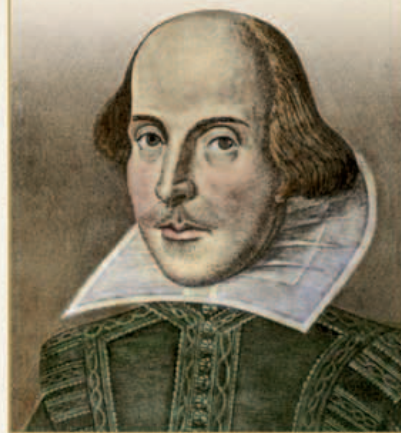
The Virgin Queen

Elizabeth’s role in the cultural flowering that occurred in England during her reign and the feats of English mariners is hard to assess. She supported the arts financially, although her taste in theater was more for clowning than for refined wit. Adventurers such as Sir Francis Drake enjoyed her fitful support, backed when their schemes served her purposes. For the last two decades of her reign, England was at war with

WRITER AND POET (1564–1616)

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE

William Shakespeare, son of a Stratford-upon-Avon wool dealer, was one of the actors and dramatists financially supported by Elizabeth I. He is considered to be the greatest writer of the English language, and is believed to have written at least 37 plays and 154 sonnets. He excelled at both comedy and tragedy, and his works explored the universal human experience. *Twelfth Night* was written specifically to be performed at court for Elizabeth I.



Spain. Elizabeth’s advisers tried to seek national security through an advantageous marriage between the queen and a foreign prince. Although Elizabeth toyed with proposals, she accepted none. Her aversion to marriage was simple. Unmarried she ruled; once married, she inevitably would have had to cede part or all of her power to her consort, as were the conventions of the day.

In Elizabeth’s later years, the deaths of favorites and counselors left her an isolated figure. Yet she never lost her popularity with her people. In her final speech to parliament before her death, she deftly balanced her arrogant sense of an untrammelled “divine right” to rule with her aspiration to lead by popular consent: “Though God hath raised me high,” she stated, “yet this I count the glory of my crown, that I have reigned with your loves.”



Drake knighted

Elizabeth I knighted Francis Drake on board his ship, the *Golden Hinde*, after his round-the-world voyage. The knighthood was a calculated political gesture, effectively giving royal backing to his plunder of the lands of the Spanish empire.

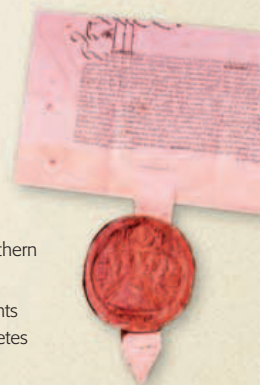
Royal offering

These gold-embroidered textile gloves were presented to Elizabeth I on a visit to Oxford University in 1566.



TIMELINE

- **September 7, 1533** Anne Boleyn gives birth to the future Elizabeth I in Greenwich Palace; she is recognized as heir presumptive to the throne ahead of her half-sister Mary, daughter of Henry’s first wife Catherine of Aragon.
- **May 19, 1536** Anne Boleyn is executed; Elizabeth is declared illegitimate and loses her right of succession to the throne.
- **June 1543** An act of parliament restores Elizabeth to the line of succession, after her brother Edward VI and sister Mary.
- **January 28, 1547** Henry VIII dies; Elizabeth becomes a ward of his widow, Catherine Parr. He is succeeded by his son, Edward VI.
- **March 20, 1549** Catherine Parr’s fourth husband, Thomas Seymour, with whom Elizabeth has been closely associated, is executed for treason.
- **July 19, 1553** Elizabeth’s Catholic sister Mary accedes to the throne.
- **March 18, 1554** Elizabeth is imprisoned in the Tower of London for alleged complicity in a rebellion against Mary led by Sir Thomas Wyatt; she is released on May 19.
- **July 25, 1554** Mary marries Philip II of Spain in Winchester Cathedral; Roman Catholicism is restored as the primary religion in England.
- **November 17, 1558** Elizabeth accedes to the throne on the death of Mary; she is crowned in Westminster Abbey on January 15, 1559.
- **May 8, 1559** The Act of Supremacy asserts the Queen as head of the Church of England, restoring the Anglican Church in place of Mary’s Catholicism.
- **1564** Elizabeth makes her favorite, Robert Dudley, the Earl of Leicester.
- **November 9, 1569** The Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmoreland lead the Northern Rebellion against Elizabeth.
- **February 20, 1570** The Northern Rebellion is defeated.
- **April 4, 1581** Elizabeth knights Francis Drake after he completes a voyage around the world.
- **1585** Anglo-Spanish War begins: Elizabeth supports the Netherlands, in revolt against Spanish rule.
- **July 1588** The Spanish Armada, an attempt by Philip II of Spain to invade England, fails.
- **1590–96** Edmund Spenser’s epic poem *The Faerie Queene*, in praise of Elizabeth (or Gloriana in the poem), is published.
- **August 4, 1598** William Cecil (later known as Baron Burghley), Elizabeth’s chief adviser since the start of her reign, dies.
- **November 30, 1601** Elizabeth makes her last address to Parliament.
- **March 24, 1603** Elizabeth dies in Richmond Palace, Surrey.



LETTER FROM ELIZABETH I TO DRAKE